CHAO FA

The story cloth · paj ntaub dab neeg

Nine squares, each one stage of the escape. Print this mat at 100% (it is 7.5 in square) and lay the nine square cards on it as they are recovered; or cut the mat into its nine squares and use them as the pieces. All nine, laid out 1 to 9, earn the crossing.



SQUARES STILL TO FIND

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7

move the cloth marker down one each time a square is sewn; at 0, the party may Cross

A party of 6 starts with squares 1 and 2 already sewn; 5 with 1 to 3; 4 with 1 to 4; 3 with 1 to 5. The squares are our own drawings in the style of the cloths first stitched in the Thai refugee camps, not copied from any real cloth.



1. The Village

1961 TO 1975 · BEFORE

Families farmed the mountain slopes. From 1961 the men were recruited into a secret army; by 1969 it counted about 39,000, and planes dropped rice to the hill airstrips when the fields could no longer be farmed.



2. The Last Planes

MAY 1975 · LEFT BEHIND

On 14 May 1975 about 2,500 officers and their families were flown out of Long Tieng. Most soldiers and their families were left at their posts and had to walk.



3. The Soldiers Come

1975 ONWARD · THE NEW GOVERNMENT

Many officers and officials were sent to re-education "seminars" in remote camps, where many were starved or worked to death. At the Hin Heup bridge, soldiers fired on Hmong marching toward Vientiane.



4. Into the Forest

1975 TO 1976 · PHOU BIA

Others went into the forest. Former soldiers joined the Chao Fa, and Phou Bia, the highest mountain in Laos, became their stronghold. Whole villages hid with them.



5. Hiding

1975 TO 1980 · IN THE JUNGLE

Families hid in the jungle with the fighters and moved on whenever the soldiers came close. One oral history speaks of more than 100,000 people in the jungles.



6. Fire from the Sky

1977 TO 1978 · THE OFFENSIVES

Vietnamese regiments were sent against Phou Bia, and thousands were killed or captured. Refugees told of "yellow rain" from aircraft; what it was is still disputed.



7. The Walk South

1975 TO 1980 · THE WAY OUT

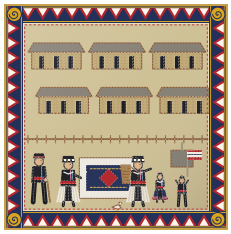
Families walked for weeks toward the Mekong, carrying children and what they could. Up to a third of the Hmong of Laos left the country.



8. The Crossing

1975 TO 1992 · THE MEKONG

They crossed at night on bamboo floats, rafts or hired boats, and were shot at from the Lao bank. No one counted how many drowned. UNHCR counted 211,344 people from Laos reaching Thailand from 1975 to 1979.



9. The Camp

1975 TO 1992 · BAN VINAI

Ban Vinai held 42,858 people at its peak, 90 percent of them Hmong, and families waited years for a country to take them. In the Thai camps they began to stitch story cloths like this one, so the story would not be lost.